

Close enough: In the India Open final, the Indians had their chances in the final game — they had closed the gap to just one point at 15-16 and 18-19 — but the Koreans held their nerve.

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unprecedented in Indian badminton. Also, their defeats have come against the very best — World champions Kang & Seo and former World No. 1, Liang Weikeng & Wang Chang from China.

In the earlier stages of the India Open, the Indian duo secured what was likely one of their sweetest victories in recent times — against Denmark's Kim Astrup & Anders Rasmussen. The 21-7, 21-10 triumph over the 2023 Worlds silver medallist ended a two-match losing streak for the Indians and erased memories of a painful upset in the quarterfinals of the 2023 World Championships.



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And now, following the Chinese pair's loss in the quarterfinals, the World No. 1 crown has been passed to the Indians once again.

Knowing Shetty and Rankireddy, it's a statistic that won't flatter them too much though. After the match, Rankireddy would reiterate what he had told *Sportstar* ahead of the start of the season — that while winning feels good, sometimes it's the losses that hold more significance in the pursuit of a larger goal.

For the Indian pair, that remains the Paris Olympics, coming up in six months. Losses like the one in Delhi and also the previous ones in Kuala Lumpur and Shenzhen allows Satwik-Chirag to work on aspects of their game that may have been previously left unresolved.



"Sometimes I feel losing is better than winning. We may have lost a few tournaments but (what that means is that) when the situation demands, we can rise to the occasion. There were a lot of moments when we could have changed the result (at the India Open), especially when it was 16-17 in the third game of the final."

"If we had five per cent more control in our shots, we would have been favourites to win. We played three finals and we lost all of them closely. All of them went to three games. We lost the final game 21-19 in China and then 21-18 (in Delhi). We could have kept calm in those crucial situations. We need to hang

in there. I think we need to have the courage to take those decisions in those situations," Satwik said.

There were also tactical issues to improve upon. "I think we were a little too aggressive in the final. We used our defense well in the quarters and semifinals. But in the final we were focussing more on just attacking. We should have used the court a bit better," Satwik would say later.

If anything the losses have only whet their appetite for bigger things. "Losing is better because it will give us a lot of motivation. Personally I am happy we lost in front of a home crowd because it gives a lot of motivation to make them happy